

The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky

Stephen Crane · 1898

First published: McClure's, Feb 1898

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Caspar David Friedrich, The Monk by the Sea (1808–1810). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Bride_Comes_to_Yellow_Sky (revision 13850340), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky suggest about the end of the Old West?
- What does The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky suggest about marriage and change?
- What does The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky suggest about comedy of expectation?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one

essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.

Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*the end of the Old West* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky

Author biography

Stephen Crane was born in Newark, New Jersey, on 1 November 1871, the fourteenth child of a Methodist minister. He worked as a journalist in New York and wrote The Red Badge of Courage (1895), a Civil War story, without having seen war. As a correspondent he survived the sinking of the steamer Commodore off Florida in January 1897, spending some thirty hours in a dinghy, the basis of "The Open Boat." He reported on the Greco-Turkish and Spanish-American wars and died of tuberculosis in Germany on 5 June 1900, aged 28.

Historical and cultural context

By the 1890s the American frontier was closing (the 1890 Census declared it closed), and railroads brought Eastern manners west. Dime stories romanticized gunfighters.

Publication and reception, then and now

Published in McClure's Magazine in February 1898.

Then: Read as a western humour piece.

Now: A parody of the western and a study of the end of the frontier.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Marshal Jack Potter returns by train with his new bride, worried about how the town will take the news. Meanwhile, the drunken gunman Scratchy Wilson is terrorizing the town.

Main themes

- the closing of the frontier: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight.
- civilization versus the Wild West.
- marriage and change.

Why it matters

It shows how a genre (the western) changes with history, and teaches students to recognize parody and anticlimax.

Spoilers · teacher only

Scratchy confronts the unarmed Potter, learns he is married, and walks away: "I s'pose it's all off now."

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky: How do rituals and rules change when life changes?
Prompt: Before we open The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky: How do rituals and rules change when life changes?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

parody; irony; anticlimax; setting.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Stephen Crane was born in Newark, New Jersey, on 1 November 1871, the fourteenth child of a Methodist minister. He worked as a journalist in New York and wrote The Red Badge of Courage (1895), a Civil War story, without having seen war. As a correspondent he survived the sinking of the steamer Commodore off Florida in January 1897, spending some thirty hours in a dinghy, the basis of "The Open Boat." He reported on the Greco-Turkish and Spanish-American wars and died of tuberculosis in Germany on 5 June 1900, aged 28. The world of the book. By the 1890s the American frontier was closing (the 1890 Census declared it closed), and railroads brought Eastern manners west. Dime stories romanticized gunfighters. Publication and reception. Published in McClure's Magazine in February 1898. Then: Read as a western humour piece. Now: A parody of the western and a study of the end of the frontier.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

“I s'pose it's all off now” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88). Scratchy's realization.

> *I s'pose it's all off now (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88)*

Think-aloud: “I s'pose it's all off now” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88). Scratchy's realization.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Marshal Jack Potter returns by train with his new bride, worried about how the town will take the news. Meanwhile, the drunken gunman Scratchy Wilson is terrorizing the town. Themes to track: the closing of the frontier: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. civilization versus the Wild West.: marriage and change.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky still matter? It shows how a genre (the western) changes with history, and teaches students to recognize parody and anticlimax.
Anchor question: Why might The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows how a genre (the western) changes with history, and teaches students to recognize parody and anticlimax.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why does Scratchy leave? Answer: Potter's marriage marks the end of the old ways.
Exit ticket: Why does Scratchy leave?
Answer: Potter's marriage marks the end of the old ways.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Stephen Crane" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Stephen-Crane); Stephen Crane Society (https://www.stephencranesociety.org/); Stephen Crane Society (https://www.stephencranesociety.org/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The month (February 1898) is commonly cited; verify.

Lesson 2: The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky

Focus: the closing of the frontier

Objective: Students will analyze how irony develops in "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (gunplay, drunkenness): Sensitive content: Gunplay; drunkenness. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes gunplay; drunkenness.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Marshal Jack Potter rides a Pullman car home to Yellow Sky with his new bride, anxious because he married without telling the town. Meanwhile drunken Scratchy Wilson terrorizes the empty street with revolvers, looking for his old enemy Potter. Scratchy confronts the unarmed marshal, hears he is married, says 'I s'pose it's all off now,' and walks away.

Background: Published in 1898. The railroad and Eastern manners reached the Southwest as the 'frontier' was declared closed (1890 census).

Significance: A parody of the Western showdown; often taught with The Open Boat.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do big life changes, like marriage, change how others see us? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to the closing of the frontier because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes gunplay; drunkenness.
Prompt: How do big life changes, like marriage, change how others see us?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to the closing of the frontier because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: dutifully — out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner; epithets — a defamatory or abusive word or phrase; narrowly — closely; carefully; antagonist — someone who offers opposition; patronage — the act of providing approval and support. “narrowly”: From Middle English narowly, equivalent to narrow + -ly. “antagonist”: From Latin antagonista, from Ancient Greek ἀνταγωνιστής *"opponent" (*ἀντί *"against" +* ἀγωνιστής *"a combatant, pleader, actor"), from* ἀνταγωνίζομαι *"to antagonize".*
Words: dutifully: out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner · epithets: a defamatory or abusive word or phrase · narrowly: closely; carefully · antagonist: someone who offers opposition · patronage: the act of providing approval and support

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1898. The railroad and Eastern manners reached the Southwest as the 'frontier' was declared closed (1890 census). A parody of the Western showdown; often taught with The Open Boat. Irony: The story builds to the classic western showdown, and it ends without a shot: Potter is unarmed and Scratchy is defeated by the word "married." Setting: The Pullman car, with its plush and its condescending porter, brings Eastern manners into the West; Yellow Sky is a town where the old ritual still plays out. Characterization: Scratchy, in a flashy shirt from New York, is "a child of the earlier plains" who plays the gunman like a game; Potter is a lawman embarrassed by his own happiness. Watch for the funnel-shaped tracks: Scratchy leaves traces that narrow and vanish, like the Old West itself.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2). Opening. That is irony at work: The story builds to the classic western showdown, and it ends without a shot: Potter is unarmed and Scratchy is defeated by the word "married."

> *A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2). Opening. That is irony at work: The story builds to the classic western showdown, and it ends without a shot: Potter is unarmed and Scratchy is defeated by the word "married."

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: A funnel narrows to a point, suggesting his way of life is shrinking to nothing. Ask: How does this line connect to the closing of the frontier? Expected: Marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. (The image.)

> *His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: A funnel narrows to a point, suggesting his way of life is shrinking to nothing.
Ask: How does this line connect to the closing of the frontier?
Expected answer: Marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. (The image.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for irony, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the closing of the frontier? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky develops the idea of the closing of the frontier. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The marriage ends the Wild West. When the text says “His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90), it shows this directly. Scratchy says "I s'pose it's all off now," and walks away, his "funnel-shaped tracks" fading.
Task: Annotate the story for irony, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the closing of the frontier? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky develops the idea of the closing of the frontier. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The marriage ends the Wild West. When the text says “His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90), it shows this directly. Scratchy says "I s'pose it's all off now," and walks away, his "funnel-shaped tracks" fading.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do big life changes, like marriage, change how others see us? Ask: is Scratchy a villain or a performer in a game that no longer has rules?
Anchor question: How do big life changes, like marriage, change how others see us?
Facilitation: Ask: is Scratchy a villain or a performer in a game that no longer has rules?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the closing of the frontier? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The marriage ends the Wild West. ("His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand", The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the closing of the frontier? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The marriage ends the Wild West. ("His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand", The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes the closing of the frontier. Key takeaway: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** The story builds to the classic western showdown, and it ends without a shot: Potter is unarmed and Scratchy is defeated by the word "married."
- **Setting:** The Pullman car, with its plush and its condescending porter, brings Eastern manners into the West; Yellow Sky is a town where the old ritual still plays out.
- **Characterization:** Scratchy, in a flashy shirt from New York, is "a child of the earlier plains" who plays the gunman like a game; Potter is a lawman embarrassed by his own happiness.

Themes and how they develop

- **the closing of the frontier:** marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight.

Symbols and motifs

- **the funnel-shaped tracks:** Scratchy leaves traces that narrow and vanish, like the Old West itself.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2) Opening.
- "I s'pose it's all off now" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88) The ending.
- "His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90) The image.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The marriage ends the Wild West.
Evidence: “His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90)
Reasoning: Scratchy says "I s'pose it's all off now," and walks away, his "funnel-shaped tracks" fading.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
dutifully (adverb)	out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner	*It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully.*	
epithets (noun)	a defamatory or abusive word or phrase	*After a decent wait, the man howled further challenges, mingling with them wonderful epithets.*	
narrowly (adverb)	closely; carefully	*The traitor to the feelings of Yellow Sky narrowly watched the speeding landscape. "We're nearly there," he said.*	“narrowly”: From Middle English narowly, equivalent to narrow + -ly. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/narrowly#Etymology)
antagonist (noun)	someone who offers opposition	*The name of Jack Potter, his ancient antagonist, entered his mind, and he concluded that it would be a glad thing if he should go to Potter's house and by bombardment induce him to come out and fight.*	“antagonist”: From Latin antagonista, from Ancient Greek ἀνταγωνιστής "opponent" (ἀντί "against" + ἀγωνιστής "a combatant, pleader, actor"), from ἀνταγωνίζομαι "to antagonize". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/antagonist#Etymology)
patronage (noun)	the act of providing approval and support	*The patronage, entwined with the ordinary deference, was not plain to them.*	
exceeded (verb)	be greater in scope or size than some standard	*It could only be exceeded by the burning of the new hotel.*	
deference (noun)	a courteous expression (by word or deed) of esteem or regard	*The patronage, entwined with the ordinary deference, was not plain to them.*	“deference”: From French déférence. Morphologically defer + ence. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/deference#Etymology)
bridegroom (noun)	a man who has recently been married	*The second weapon was aimed at the bridegroom's chest.*	

attracted (verb)	direct toward itself or oneself by means of some psychological power or physical attributes	*Ultimately the man was attracted by the closed door of the "Weary Gentleman" saloon.*	"attracted": From Latin attractus, past participle of attrahere "to draw to, attract", from ad "to" + trahere "to draw". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/attract#Etymology)
remaining (verb)	stay the same; remain in a certain state	*The door remaining imperturbable, he picked a bit of paper from the walk and nailed it to the framework with a knife.*	"remaining": By surface analysis, remain + -ing. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/remaining#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. How do big life changes, like marriage, change how others see us?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with the end of the Old West?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How is Potter traveling home? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: In a Pullman train car
2. Why is Potter nervous? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: He married without telling the town
3. What is Scratchy Wilson doing when the train arrives? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Drunkenly shooting up the town
4. Is Potter armed when he meets Scratchy? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: No, he has no gun
5. Why does Scratchy end the fight? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: He learns Potter is married
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Marshal Jack Potter rides a Pullman car home to Yellow Sky with his new bride, anxious because he married without telling the town. Meanwhile drunken Scratchy Wilson terrorizes the empty street with revolvers, looking for his old enemy Potter. Scratchy confronts the unarmed marshal, hears he is married, says 'I s'pose it's all off now,' and walks away.

7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully." What does "dutifully" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: dutifully: out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner.
10. Reread: "After a decent wait, the man howled further challenges, mingling with them wonderful epithets." What does "epithets" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: epithets: a defamatory or abusive word or phrase.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky" suggest about the closing of the frontier? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A parody of the Western showdown; often taught with The Open Boat.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about the closing of the frontier? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2): Opening. On setting: The Pullman car, with its plush and its condescending porter, brings Eastern manners into the West; Yellow Sky is a town where the old ritual still plays out. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins "The bride was not pretty, nor was she very young.", why might Crane have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Marshal Jack Potter rides a Pullman car home to Yellow Sky with his new bride, anxious because he married without telling the town. Meanwhile drunken Scratchy Wilson terrorizes the empty street with revolvers, looking for his old enemy Potter. Scratchy confronts the unarmed marshal, hears he is…
6. As the opening story, what does "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky" set up that the rest of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "I s'pose it's all off now" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88): The ending. Theme link: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: “His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90): The image. On characterization: Scratchy, in a flashy shirt from New York, is "a child of the earlier plains" who plays the gunman like a game; Potter is a lawman embarrassed by his own happiness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How do big life changes, like marriage, change how others see us?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with the end of the Old West? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: “A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2): Opening. On characterization: Scratchy, in a flashy shirt from New York, is "a child of the earlier plains" who plays the gunman like a game; Potter is a lawman embarrassed by his own happiness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1898. The railroad and Eastern manners reached the Southwest as the 'frontier' was declared closed (1890 census). How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: “I s'pose it's all off now” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88): The ending. On setting: The Pullman car, with its plush and its condescending porter, brings Eastern manners into the West; Yellow Sky is a town where the old ritual still plays out. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A parody of the Western showdown; often taught with The Open Boat.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: “His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90): The image. Theme link: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: “A

newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2): Opening. On characterization: Scratchy, in a flashy shirt from New York, is "a child of the earlier plains" who plays the gunman like a game; Potter is a lawman embarrassed by his own happiness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the closing of the frontier? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "I s'pose it's all off now" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88): The ending. Theme link: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90): The image. Theme link: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to marriage and change: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Crane need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2): Opening. Theme link: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "I s'pose it's all off now" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88): The ending. On irony: The story builds to the classic western showdown, and it ends without a shot: Potter is unarmed and Scratchy is defeated by the word "married." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky" treats the closing of the frontier with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90): The image. Theme link: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve the end of the Old West? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2): Opening. Theme link: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the closing of the frontier? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "I s'pose it's all off now" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88): The ending. Theme link: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Stephen Crane about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The marriage ends the Wild West. Useful evidence: "His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90): The image. Theme link: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Is Potter armed when he meets Scratchy?

   A. Yes, with a rifle

   B. He has a knife

   C. No, he has no gun

   D. Yes, with two pistols

   Key: C (No, he has no gun)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The second weapon was aimed at the _____'s chest." Word bank: bridegroom, dutifully, epithets, narrowly

   Key: bridegroom
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The _____, entwined with the ordinary deference, was not plain to them." Word bank: narrowly, patronage, epithets, dutifully

   Key: patronage

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Scratchy Wilson doing when the train arrives?
   A. Drunkenly shooting up the town
   B. Sleeping
   C. Working in the saloon
   D. Waiting to greet Potter

   Key: A (Drunkenly shooting up the town)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "It could only be _____ by the burning of the new hotel." Word bank: dutifully, epithets, exceeded, narrowly

   Key: exceeded

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why does Scratchy end the fight?
   A. He learns Potter is married
   B. The sheriff arrives
   C. He runs out of bullets
   D. Potter shoots him

   Key: A (He learns Potter is married)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2: "A newly _____ pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio"

   Key: married

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The patronage, entwined with the ordinary _____, was not plain to them." Word bank: deference, narrowly, dutifully, epithets

   Key: deference

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90: "His feet made _____-shaped tracks in the heavy sand"

   Key: funnel

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why is Potter nervous?
    A. He married without telling the town
    B. He owes money
    C. He lost his badge
    D. He is wanted by the law

    Key: A (He married without telling the town)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Opening.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "I s'pose it's all off now" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The ending.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky"?
    A. The closing of the frontier
    B. Harlem as promised refuge and trap
    C. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

D. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

Key: A (The closing of the frontier)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The image.
15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The marriage ends the Wild West. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90).
    Sample answer: Scratchy says "I s'pose it's all off now," and walks away, his "funnel-shaped tracks" fading.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Opening.
17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky”? The Pullman car, with its plush and its condescending porter, brings Eastern manners into the West; Yellow Sky is a town where the old ritual still plays out.

    A. Diction / vocabulary

    B. Setting

    C. Irony

    D. Hyperbole

    Key: B (Setting)
18. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky”? The story builds to the classic western showdown, and it ends without a shot: Potter is unarmed and Scratchy is defeated by the word "married."

    A. Hyperbole

    B. Simile

    C. Diction / vocabulary

    D. Irony

    Key: D (Irony)
19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I s'pose it's all off now” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The ending.
20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How is Potter traveling home?

    A. In a Pullman train car

    B. By stagecoach

    C. On horseback

    D. On foot

    Key: A (In a Pullman train car)
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The marriage ends the Wild West.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Scratchy says "I s'pose it's all off now," and walks away, his "funnel-shaped tracks" fading.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how the closing of the frontier develops from an earlier story to "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky". Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully.", what does "dutifully" most nearly mean?

    A. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

    B. someone who offers opposition

    C. closely; carefully

    D. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner

    Key: D (out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "The traitor to the feelings of Yellow Sky narrowly watched the speeding landscape. "We're nearly there," he said.", what does "narrowly" most nearly mean?

    A. closely; carefully

    B. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

    C. someone who offers opposition

    D. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner

    Key: A (closely; carefully)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "After a decent wait, the man howled further challenges, mingling with them wonderful epithets.", what does "epithets" most nearly mean?

    A. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner

    B. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

    C. closely; carefully

    D. someone who offers opposition

    Key: B (a defamatory or abusive word or phrase)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 7, 4, 6, 1, 8, 9, 10, 2, 13, 12, 11, 17, 18, 15, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	9, 6, 8, 4, 20, 5, 1, 7, 13, 12, 11, 18, 15, 14, 16, 21	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 3, 4, 20, 1, 5, 8, 12, 13, 11, 14, 18, 17, 15, 21, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	7, 5, 10, 9, 8, 20, 12, 11, 13, 14, 18, 17, 15, 22, 16, 21	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	23, 5, 20, 8, 9, 11, 12, 13, 17, 14, 15, 18, 16, 19, 22, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	4, 9, 24, 6, 7, 13, 12, 11, 18, 15, 14, 17, 16, 19, 21, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	4, 7, 8, 9, 2, 13, 12, 11, 15, 17, 18, 14, 22, 19, 16, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	23, 7, 20, 25, 5, 12, 13, 11, 15, 14, 17, 18, 19, 16, 22, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	5, 10, 20, 3, 1, 11, 13, 12, 18, 17, 14, 15, 22, 21, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	1, 9, 2, 8, 4, 11, 12, 13, 15, 18, 17, 14, 21, 22, 19, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky,” how does Crane show the closing of the frontier? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1): In The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, how does Crane develop the idea of the closing of the frontier? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky develops the idea of the closing of the frontier. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of the closing of the frontier. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky suggests about the closing of the frontier. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Stephen Crane uses irony in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky to complicate the reader's understanding of the closing of the frontier. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Situate The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the closing of the frontier responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Read The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the closing of the frontier follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky and its treatment of the closing of the frontier. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Develop a research argument that reads The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky as evidence for a larger claim about the closing of the frontier in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Develop an original argument that reads The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the closing of the frontier. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky.

SAT-style questions

1. *The traitor to the feelings of Yellow Sky narrowly watched the speeding landscape. "We're nearly there," he said.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “narrowly” most nearly mean?

   A. closely; carefully

   B. stay the same; remain in a certain state

   C. a man who has recently been married

   D. direct toward itself or oneself by means of some psychological power or physical attributes

2. *The bride was not pretty, nor was she very young. She wore a dress of blue cashmere, with small reservations of velvet here and there and with steel buttons abounding. She continually twisted her head to regard her puff sleeves, very stiff, straight, and high. They embarrassed her. It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully. The blushes caused by the careless scrutiny of some passengers as she had entered the car were strange to see upon this plain, under-class countenance, which was drawn in placid, almost emotionless lines.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky”?

   A. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

   B. The closing of the frontier

   C. A woman's brief taste of freedom

   D. A story so convincing it becomes real

SAT key: 1. A (closely; carefully); 2. B (The closing of the frontier)

Unit test

The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90: “His feet made _____-shaped tracks in the heavy sand”
   Key: funnel
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The second weapon was aimed at the _____'s chest.” Word bank: bridegroom, dutifully, epithets, narrowly
   Key: bridegroom
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “It could only be _____ by the burning of the new hotel.” Word bank: dutifully, epithets, exceeded, narrowly
   Key: exceeded
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2: “A newly _____ pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio”
   Key: married
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How is Potter traveling home?
   A. In a Pullman train car
   B. By stagecoach
   C. On horseback
   D. On foot

   Key: A (In a Pullman train car)
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The _____, entwined with the ordinary deference, was not plain to them.” Word bank: narrowly, patronage, epithets, dutifully
   Key: patronage
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why is Potter nervous?
   A. He married without telling the town
   B. He owes money
   C. He lost his badge
   D. He is wanted by the law

   Key: A (He married without telling the town)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The patronage, entwined with the ordinary _____, was not plain to them." Word bank: deference, narrowly, dutifully, epithets

    Key: deference

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why does Scratchy end the fight?

    A. He learns Potter is married

    B. The sheriff arrives

    C. He runs out of bullets

    D. Potter shoots him

    Key: A (He learns Potter is married)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Scratchy Wilson doing when the train arrives?

    A. Drunkenly shooting up the town

    B. Sleeping

    C. Working in the saloon

    D. Waiting to greet Potter

    Key: A (Drunkenly shooting up the town)

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Is Potter armed when he meets Scratchy?

    A. Yes, with a rifle

    B. He has a knife

    C. No, he has no gun

    D. Yes, with two pistols

    Key: C (No, he has no gun)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Opening.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "I s'pose it's all off now" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The ending.

14. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky"?

    A. The closing of the frontier

    B. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

    C. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

    D. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

    Key: A (The closing of the frontier)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in "His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 90). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The image.

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The marriage ends the Wild West. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: "His feet made funnel-shaped tracks in the heavy sand" (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph

90).

Sample answer: Scratchy says "I s'pose it's all off now," and walks away, his "funnel-shaped tracks" fading.

17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky”? The Pullman car, with its plush and its condescending porter, brings Eastern manners into the West; Yellow Sky is a town where the old ritual still plays out.

    A. Diction / vocabulary

    B. Setting

    C. Irony

    D. Hyperbole

    Key: B (Setting)

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “A newly married pair had boarded this coach at San Antonio” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 2) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Opening.

19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky”? The story builds to the classic western showdown, and it ends without a shot: Potter is unarmed and Scratchy is defeated by the word "married."

    A. Hyperbole

    B. Simile

    C. Diction / vocabulary

    D. Irony

    Key: D (Irony)

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I s'pose it's all off now” (The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, paragraph 88) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The ending.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how the closing of the frontier develops from an earlier story to “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: marriage, domesticity and the railroad replace the gunfight.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The marriage ends the Wild West.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Scratchy says "I s'pose it's all off now," and walks away, his "funnel-shaped tracks" fading.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The name of Jack Potter, his ancient antagonist, entered his mind, and he concluded that it would be a glad thing if he should go to Potter's house and by bombardment induce him to come out and fight.”, what does “antagonist” most nearly mean?

    A. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

    B. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner

    C. someone who offers opposition

    D. closely; carefully

    Key: C (someone who offers opposition)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “After a decent wait, the man howled further challenges, mingling with them wonderful epithets.”, what does “epithets” most nearly mean?

    A. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner

    B. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

    C. closely; carefully

    D. someone who offers opposition

    Key: B (a defamatory or abusive word or phrase)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully.”, what does “dutifully” most nearly mean?

    A. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

    B. someone who offers opposition

    C. closely; carefully

    D. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner

    Key: D (out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The traitor to the feelings of Yellow Sky narrowly watched the speeding landscape. "We're nearly there," he said.”, what does “narrowly” most nearly mean?

    A. closely; carefully

    B. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

    C. someone who offers opposition

    D. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner

    Key: A (closely; carefully)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	6, 7, 5, 8, 10, 1, 4, 9, 2, 11, 3, 14, 12, 13, 19, 15, 17, 20	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	6, 1, 3, 11, 7, 10, 8, 5, 9, 2, 13, 12, 14, 19, 17, 16, 21, 20	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	5, 6, 11, 9, 4, 7, 8, 3, 1, 12, 13, 14, 19, 15, 17, 16, 20, 21	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 5, 10, 1, 6, 3, 8, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 19, 17, 22, 20, 18	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	5, 23, 10, 1, 8, 2, 24, 14, 13, 12, 15, 16, 17, 19, 18, 21, 20, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	1, 25, 8, 5, 3, 24, 9, 12, 14, 13, 16, 19, 17, 15, 20, 21, 18, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	1, 4, 3, 7, 25, 8, 10, 13, 14, 12, 15, 19, 16, 17, 18, 22, 21, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior		

	2, 7, 5, 4, 26, 3, 24, 13, 12, 14, 17, 15, 19, 16, 22, 20, 18, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	6, 1, 23, 2, 5, 25, 8, 14, 13, 12, 16, 17, 15, 19, 21, 22, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	6, 1, 26, 7, 4, 5, 25, 12, 14, 13, 19, 16, 15, 17, 21, 22, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Stephen Crane develops the end of the Old West across The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to marriage and change.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of comedy of expectation. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: The end of the Old West

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky teaches about the end of the Old West. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops the end of the Old West across The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the end of the Old West. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the end of the Old West, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky's treatment of the end of the Old West in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging

at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Marriage and change

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky teaches about marriage and change. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops marriage and change across The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of marriage and change. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of marriage and change, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky's treatment of marriage and change in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Comedy of expectation

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky teaches about comedy of expectation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops comedy of expectation across The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of comedy of expectation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of comedy of expectation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky's treatment of comedy of expectation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary or Wiktionary, 2026-10-20); unverified ones are left out. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.